

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Impact vs. Intent

Mia did not mean to leave Sofia out of the New Year's Eve call.

This is the most important sentence in this chapter, and it is also the sentence that does not, by itself, repair anything. Mia did not mean to leave Sofia out, and Sofia was left out. Both of those things are true. Both of those things are independent of each other. The repair, when it eventually happens, has to account for both.

But first, here is what happened.

On New Year's Eve, Mia in Pittsburgh had three of her Pittsburgh friends over. They were going to do a small thing — a movie, snacks, a video call with one Pittsburgh friend who was out of town in Florida visiting family. The plan had been small. Mia had set up the video call for ten p.m. her time, which would be ten p.m. Pittsburgh time, which would also be ten p.m. Lincoln Park time, because they are in the same time zone.

The cohort, in Lincoln Park, had its own New Year's Eve plan. Sofia's house. Most of the cohort. Movie. Snacks. The usual cohort basement gathering.

Mia had, on Mia's end, been planning to also call Sofia at midnight, the way they did most New Year's Eves. The midnight call was a tradition. What Mia had not done was put Sofia on the ten p.m. video call list with the Pittsburgh friends.

The ten p.m. call was a Pittsburgh-friends thing, in Mia's head, separate from the midnight Sofia call.

Sofia, in Lincoln Park, at ten p.m., was on her phone in the cohort basement when she saw a post Mia had made — a quick snap of the four Pittsburgh friends laughing on a video call. The post was captioned *NYE crew*.

Sofia stared at the post for a long second.

Sofia had been Mia's NYE call for six years.

Sofia had not been on this call.

Sofia put her phone down.

The cohort was watching a movie. Marcus, who was on the couch next to Sofia, noticed Sofia's face go still. Marcus, who has been the cohort's most reliable detector of Sofia going still since first grade, did not say anything immediately. Marcus just nudged her shoulder gently with his.

Sofia said, quietly, *I am fine*.

Marcus said, *Sof*.

Sofia said, *I am*.

Marcus said, *okay*.

Sofia, by 11:45 p.m., had been sitting with the small wound for an hour and forty-five minutes.

The midnight call came in. Mia, on the screen, smiling. Sofia answered. Sofia, for thirty seconds, did the *happy new year* version. Then Sofia said, *Mi, I have to go, the cohort wants to do midnight things*. The cohort was, in fact, not doing midnight things. The cohort was watching the movie. Sofia hung up.

Mia, in Pittsburgh, stared at her phone for ten seconds.

Mia, in Pittsburgh, knew immediately that something was wrong. The cohort, for six years, had not cut Mia's midnight call short. The midnight call had been, by long-running tradition, ten to fifteen minutes. The hanging up at thirty

seconds was — Mia could feel — a sentence Sofia had not yet said out loud.

Mia did not text Sofia that night. Mia waited until the next morning.

Mia texted: *Sof. Are you okay.*

Sofia texted back, two hours later: *Mi. I am fine.*

Mia texted: *Sof. You are not fine. The midnight call was thirty seconds. Are you mad at me?*

Sofia, in her bedroom in Lincoln Park, sat with the phone for ten minutes. She typed three different responses. She deleted all three. She finally typed:

I saw the post from your ten p.m. call. I was not on it. I have been on every NYE call we have done since we were nine. I know it is — I know it is dumb. But it hurt. I am sad. I will get over it. I am going to take some time.

She hit send.

Mia, in Pittsburgh, read it.

Mia immediately understood several things at once.

Mia had not meant to leave Sofia off the ten p.m. call. Mia had been thinking about the call as the Pittsburgh-friends call, separate from the Lincoln Park midnight call. The two had been, in Mia's head, two different events. Mia had not, in her own head, excluded Sofia from anything. Sofia was on the midnight call, the way she had always been.

But — and this was the part Mia immediately got — Sofia did not have Mia's head. Sofia had Sofia's head. Sofia's head had seen a post of Mia's NYE crew that Sofia was not in. The version of the night that Sofia had received was: *Mia has new NYE crew, and Sofia is not in it.*

That was the impact. The impact did not care what Mia had intended.

Mia thought for a long minute about what to say.

She typed:

Sof. You are not dumb. I get it. I made a mistake. I had two calls in my head – the Pittsburgh-friends one and our midnight one – and I did not realize that you would see the Pittsburgh one and feel left out. I should have put you on the Pittsburgh one. Or I should have called you separately at ten and explained. Or I should have at least told you in advance there was a ten p.m. one. The thing is – I did not, in my head, leave you out. But I did. In your experience, I left you out. The intention does not change that. I am sorry.

She read it. She sent it.

Sofia, in Lincoln Park, read it.

Sofia, in Lincoln Park, started crying. Not big crying. Small relief crying.

Sofia texted: *Mi. Thank you. I needed to hear that. I am – I am still going to take the day. But thank you.*

Mia texted: *Sof. Take the day. Call me tomorrow.*

Sofia took the day. Sofia called Mia on the second of January. They talked for an hour. The thing was, by the end of the call, resolved.

But this is not just a story about a thing being resolved. This is a story about a phrase, and the phrase is important enough that we are going to spend some time on it.

The phrase is:

Impact is not determined by intent.



What Mia intended was to invite three Pittsburgh friends to a ten p.m. call. What she actually did, in the world, was leave Sofia out of an NYE moment that Sofia had been part of for six years. The intention does not change the impact. The impact does not change the intention either.

But — and this is the part that takes most people years to learn — *repair addresses impact, not intent.*

That is the part nobody is told.

When you have hurt somebody, even by accident, the question is not whether you meant to. The question is what landed. The question is what they experienced. The question is what they are now carrying because of something you did, whether or not you intended it.

The intention is your internal fact. The impact is the external fact. The internal fact does not, by itself, undo the external one. The intention does not magically un-hurt the person.

That said: the intention is not worthless, either.

Knowing the intention helps the person you hurt contextualize what happened. *Mia did not mean to leave me out* is, for Sofia, a real piece of information. It changes the story Sofia tells herself about Mia. It means Mia is not, in Sofia's mind, the kind of friend who is rotating Sofia out for Pittsburgh friends on purpose. The intention is, in some real way, exculpatory — it tells Sofia about who Mia is.

But the intention is exculpatory for Mia. It is not curative for Sofia. The hurt is in Sofia. The hurt does not go away because Mia did not intend it.

What does — sometimes — make the hurt go away is the repair. And the repair has a shape.

Mia's text — *I get it. I made a mistake. I should have put you on the Pittsburgh one. Or I should have called you separately. The intention does not change that. I am sorry* — is the shape.

The shape is:

One. *I see the impact.*

Two. *I am not defending the intention as a way to dismiss the impact.*

Three. *I am sorry.*

That is the whole repair. Three lines. It does not take a paragraph. It does not require Mia to perform regret beyond what is genuine. It does not require Mia to grovel.

What it does require is that Mia not defend the intention. That is the trap most people fall into. Most people, when they have hurt somebody by accident, say *I did not mean to* and *I did not mean to* and *I did not mean to*, over and over, because they think the saying-it-again will eventually convince the person that the impact was not real. The repeating does the opposite. The repeating makes the hurt person feel unseen — because their hurt is being treated as something that should be made smaller by Mia's intention, and the hurt is not being made smaller. The repeating, in some real way, adds to the hurt.

The shape of the actual repair is one mention of intention — *I did not mean to* — followed by acknowledgment of impact — *but I see that I did* — and then apology.

One. Once. Then move on.

Mia, at twelve, had this shape because Mia had, like the rest of the cohort, been doing the *acknowledge, repair, commit, move on* practice since fourth grade. Mia knew the shape in her muscles. The text she wrote came out fast because the shape was already there.

Most adults, even, do not have this shape.

Most adults, when they hurt somebody by accident, perform a kind of defensive intention-explanation that the hurt person experiences as further injury.

You — the kids reading this — are being given the shape at twelve. That is a gift.

Use it.

The shape does not solve every hurt. The shape does not, in some cases, fully heal a wound. But the shape is — in the same way the four steps for mistakes are — the architecture of the repair. The shape gives you something to build with. You can do the shape badly the first ten times. You will get better.

By the time you are twenty, you will be one of the small number of people in the world who has, in their muscles, the practice of *I see the impact, I am not defending the intention, I am sorry*.

That is the work of Chapter Fourteen.

That is the beginning of Part Three.

The rest of Part Three is about what happens when somebody hurts you and does not do the shape. What happens when the impact is real and the repair never comes. What happens when you are the kid sitting with a thing the other kid is not going to acknowledge.

That is the harder part of forgiveness.

That is most of forgiveness, in fact.

We start it in Chapter Fifteen.

— J.A.R.